urged the Chinese premier not to back out of armistice talks.[27] In order to prevent this and strengthen Eisenhower's hand, Nehru pushed for the reconvening of the UN General Assembly as soon as possible. This interjection, however, annoyed Dulles, who believed that bringing more parties into the discussions would only complicate the matter.[28]

With India as chair of the NNRC, Indian policymakers, as Nehru's biographer put it, felt they were in a "thankless position" with "both sides accusing India of partisanship."[29] American observers charged that India accepted Chinese and North Korean allegations that Taiwan was instigating anticommunist prisoners to riot, while ignoring US allegations about the communists doing the same.[30] Senate majority leader Knowland accused India of giving in to all Chinese demands; in response, Dulles indicated the administration's displeasure with some of the NNRC's functioning.[31] China, on the other hand, criticized India for not using force to coerce Chinese and North Korean POWs to return to their home countries.[32] It then vociferously condemned the Indian chair's announcement that the NNRC would return unrepatriated POWs to their captors by January 22, 1954.[33] Even some in the US who wanted India to release all unrepatriated POWs complained about that step.[34] Delhi was not pleased when the US subsequently released them.

The Eisenhower administration's move to exclude India from the postarmistice political conference also did not win it any friends there. Nehru had expected that India would be asked to participate.[35] But, despite Australian, British, and Canadian support, the US refused to endorse Indian participation, largely because of the objections of South Korea, which accused India of "trafficking with the Communists."[36] India critic Knowland told Robertson that India's "dubious" record should take it out of contention.[37] The US subsequently announced that it would vote against extending India an invitation.[38] China, on the other hand, supported Indian participation and even suggested Delhi as a possible venue for the conference—thereby scoring propaganda points with India.[39]

To save face and the conference, Nehru withdrew India from consideration. He stated that the US step was one more example of the West excluding Asians from decisionmaking that affected Asia. Asian countries, he asserted, would no longer be "ignored or bypassed, certainly not sat upon."[40] It was around this time that Indian policymakers also started